



HOW DARE YOU CALL ME A HAM?

TO BE OR NOT TO BE / 1942

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

War comedy

DIRECTOR

Ernst Lubitsch

WRITERS

**Melchior Lengyel,
Edwin Justus Mayer**

STARS

Jack Benny, Carole Lombard, Robert Stack

BEFORE

1940 *The Shop Around the Corner*, Lubitsch's hit romantic comedy, is also set in Europe on the eve of World War II.

AFTER

1943 After the disappointing initial reception of *To Be or Not to Be*, Lubitsch returns to more conventional comedies with *Heaven Can Wait*.

1983 *To Be or Not to Be* is remade, with husband-and-wife comedy actors Mel Brooks and Anne Bancroft in the lead roles.

It's astonishing now to realize that Ernst Lubitsch's hilarious satire of the Nazis began production in 1941, when the US had not yet entered World War II and was still maintaining neutrality. German-born Lubitsch set out to challenge that neutrality. Knowing the political risk he was taking, he took himself out of the studio system for the first time in his career and signed a deal with United Artists. This paid him less than his usual fee but gave him artistic control.

The story was unusual for Lubitsch in that it was not taken from an existing source, but was developed by him with two trusted collaborators, Hungarian screenwriter Melchior Lengyel, and US playwright Edwin Justus Mayer.

Actors' vanity

The starting point was Lubitsch's memories of the vanity of actors during his years on the Berlin stage, and his observation that



The movie's release in March 1942 was marred by tragedy. Carole Lombard had died in a plane crash weeks earlier, while work was in postproduction.

actors remain actors, no matter what situation they're in. But the story quickly became much darker than that.

Although it was

made in Hollywood, the movie is set in Warsaw, Poland, in 1939, just as Germany is about to invade. The highly strung members of a theater company—led by Joseph Tura (Jack Benny) and the leading lady who is also his wife, Maria (Carole Lombard)—are rehearsing an anti-Nazi spoof by day and performing Shakespeare's *Hamlet* by night. When Maria becomes romantically involved with a dashing young admirer, pilot Lieutenant Stanislaw Sobinski (Robert

